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National Institute of Applied Science and Technology

Department of Physics and Instrumentation

Industrial Instrumentation and Maintenance

Summer Internship Report

Pipe Reverse Engineering Workflow Automation Using Fusion 360 API

Automation of LRT Innovation Labs' Pipe Production SOP



Author: Aziz Moualhi

Supervisor: Adel Ayari
LRT Innovation Labs, Tunis

Institution: INSAT
National Institute of Applied Science and Technology

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Contents

1	Background and Problem Statement	4
1.1	Company Overview: LRT Innovation Labs	4
1.2	Current Workflow: Manual SOP	4
1.3	Problem Definition	4
1.4	Project Scope	5
2	Mathematical Foundations and LRA Derivation	7
2.1	Overview of Bending Calculations	7
2.2	Coordinate System and Bend Point Extraction	7
2.2.1	Input: Sketch Geometry	7
2.2.2	Bend Point Calculation	7
2.3	Bend Angle (A) Calculation	8
2.4	Rotation (R) Calculation	8
2.4.1	Normal Vector Calculation	8
2.4.2	Rotation Angle Between Planes	8
2.4.3	Rotation Sign (Critical Fix)	9
2.5	Length (L) Calculation	9
2.6	Total Length Calculation	9
3	Implementation and Technical Challenges	12
3.1	Development Environment	12
3.2	Architecture	12
3.3	Challenge 1: Line/Arc Chaining	12
3.3.1	Problem	12
3.3.2	Solution	12
3.4	Challenge 2: Rotation Sign Calculation	13
3.4.1	Problem	13
3.4.2	Solution	13
3.4.3	Validation	13
3.5	Challenge 3: Automatic Coordinate System Transformation	13
3.5.1	Problem	13
3.5.2	Solution	14
3.5.3	Validation	14
3.6	Challenge 4: THOMAN Machine Table Format	14
3.6.1	Problem	14
3.6.2	Solution	14

3.7	Challenge 5: Point Normalization and Coordinate Display	15
3.7.1	Problem	15
3.7.2	Solution	15
3.8	Code Structure	15
4	Results and Validation	18
4.1	Validation Methodology	18
4.2	Test Results	18
4.2.1	Test Pipe 1: 4-Bend Pipe (Sample 44000302_PIPE_01)	18
4.3	Total Length Validation	19
4.4	THOMAN Machine Table	19
4.5	Performance Metrics	19
4.6	Conclusion	20
5	Reverse Reconstruction: From THOMAN Values to 3D Geometry	22
5.1	Motivation	22
5.2	Mathematical Formulation of the Inverse Problem	23
5.2.1	Recovering Straight-Segment Lengths from Start Positions	23
5.2.2	Reconstructing Direction and Bend-Plane Vectors	24
5.2.3	Orientation Ambiguity	24
5.3	Implementation	25
5.3.1	Standalone Validation Script	25
5.3.2	Fusion 360 Add-in Interface	25
5.4	Validation	26
5.5	Chapter Conclusion	26
6	Conclusion and Future Work	28
6.1	Summary	28
6.1.1	Key Achievements	28
6.2	Technical Innovation	28
6.3	Business Impact	29
6.4	Spring Back Analysis (Theoretical)	29
6.4.1	Spring Back Physics	29
6.4.2	Current LRT Approach	29
6.4.3	Future Enhancement: Analytical Spring Back Prediction	30
6.4.4	Implementation Recommendation	30
6.5	Limitations	30
6.6	Recommendations for Production Deployment	31
6.7	Conclusion	31
	Bibliography	32

Chapter 1

Background and Problem Statement

Chapter 1

Background and Problem Statement

1.1 Company Overview: LRT Innovation Labs

LRT Innovation Labs is a specialized company focused on innovation and precision exhaust system manufacturing. Leveraging cutting-edge technology to deliver scalable, efficient, and high-quality manufacturing solutions

1.2 Current Workflow: Manual SOP

The standard operating procedure (SOP) for pipe reverse engineering consisted of 11 steps, with the most time-consuming phases being:

- Manual measurement of pipe intersection points using Fusion 360's measure tool
- Coordinate extraction and manual entry into Excel spreadsheets
- Calculation of bending parameters (Length, Rotation, Bend Angle)
- Generation of machine instructions for the THOMAN bending machine

Each pipe processing cycle required approximately **10 minutes** for the measurement and calculation phase alone.

1.3 Problem Definition

The manual approach presented several challenges:

- **Time-intensive:** 10 minutes per pipe for data extraction and calculation
- **Error-prone:** Manual typing and coordinate entry introduced inconsistencies
- **Repetitive:** Same sequence of operations for every pipe design
- **Limited flexibility:** Testing design variations was slow and cumbersome
- **Quality control:** No automated verification of calculated values

1.4 Project Scope

This internship project aimed to automate the measurement-to-machine-instruction pipeline by creating a Fusion 360 add-in that:

- Automatically extracts pipe centerline geometry from Fusion sketches
- Calculates precise bend points by extending line segments mathematically
- Computes LRA/YBC bending parameters using LRT's verified formulas
- Generates THOMAN machine tables with final production coordinates
- Exports all results to formatted Excel files
- Reduces processing time from 10 minutes to **5 seconds per pipe**
- Provides a companion reverse-reconstruction tool (Chapter 5) that rebuilds the 3D centerline directly from edited THOMAN values, letting developers verify manual optimizations before cutting a pipe

Chapter 2

Mathematical Foundations

Chapter 2

Mathematical Foundations and LRA Derivation

2.1 Overview of Bending Calculations

The pipe bending analysis relies on three core mathematical components:

- **Length (L):** Straight segment length between bend points
- **Rotation (R):** Angle of rotation between consecutive bends
- **Bend Angle (A):** Interior angle at each bend point

2.2 Coordinate System and Bend Point Extraction

2.2.1 Input: Sketch Geometry

Fusion 360 sketches consist of straight lines and arc fillets. The sketch provides:

- Line segments $L_1, L_2, \dots, L_n$ (start and end points in 3D)
- Arc/fillet curves $A_1, A_2, \dots, A_{n-1}$ (connecting consecutive lines tangentially)

2.2.2 Bend Point Calculation

True intersection points (where bends occur) are found by extending consecutive straight lines until they intersect in 3D space. Given two consecutive lines:

$$\mathbf{L}_i : \mathbf{p} = \mathbf{p}_1 + t \cdot \mathbf{d}_1 \quad (2.1)$$

$$\mathbf{L}_{i+1} : \mathbf{p} = \mathbf{p}_2 + s \cdot \mathbf{d}_2 \quad (2.2)$$

where $\mathbf{d}_1 = \mathbf{p}_2 - \mathbf{p}_1$ and $\mathbf{d}_2 = \mathbf{p}_4 - \mathbf{p}_3$.

The intersection point is found by solving:

$$\mathbf{p}_1 + t \cdot \mathbf{d}_1 = \mathbf{p}_2 + s \cdot \mathbf{d}_2 \quad (2.3)$$

This gives the true bend center in 3D space, independent of the fillet arc radius.

2.3 Bend Angle (A) Calculation

The bend angle is the angle between two consecutive line directions.

Given direction vectors $\mathbf{v}_1$ and $\mathbf{v}_2$ (normalized):

$$\cos(\text{Angle}) = \frac{\mathbf{v}_1 \cdot \mathbf{v}_2}{|\mathbf{v}_1| \cdot |\mathbf{v}_2|} \quad (2.4)$$

$$A = \arccos\left(\frac{\mathbf{v}_1 \cdot \mathbf{v}_2}{|\mathbf{v}_1| \cdot |\mathbf{v}_2|}\right) \quad (2.5)$$

Result is in radians; convert to degrees for machine instructions.

2.4 Rotation (R) Calculation

Rotation measures how much the bend plane rotates in 3D space relative to the previous bend.

2.4.1 Normal Vector Calculation

For each bend, calculate the normal to the bend plane:

$$\mathbf{n} = \mathbf{v}_{\text{prev}} \times \mathbf{v}_{\text{curr}} \quad (2.6)$$

where $\times$ denotes the cross product.

2.4.2 Rotation Angle Between Planes

The rotation angle between consecutive bend planes:

$$\cos(\text{Rot}) = \frac{\mathbf{n}_{\text{prev}} \cdot \mathbf{n}_{\text{curr}}}{|\mathbf{n}_{\text{prev}}| \cdot |\mathbf{n}_{\text{curr}}|} \quad (2.7)$$

$$R = \arccos\left(\frac{\mathbf{n}_{\text{prev}} \cdot \mathbf{n}_{\text{curr}}}{|\mathbf{n}_{\text{prev}}| \cdot |\mathbf{n}_{\text{curr}}|}\right) \quad (2.8)$$

2.4.3 Rotation Sign (Critical Fix)

The rotation angle must be signed to indicate direction (CW vs CCW). This is determined by checking if the middle direction vector $\mathbf{v}_{\text{curr}}$ points toward the rotation axis:

$$\text{Rotation Axis} = \mathbf{n}_{\text{prev}} \times \mathbf{n}_{\text{curr}} \quad (2.9)$$

$$\text{sign} = \begin{cases} +1 & \text{if } \mathbf{v}_{\text{curr}} \cdot \text{Rotation Axis} \geq 0 \\ -1 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \quad (2.10)$$

$$R_{\text{signed}} = R \times \text{sign} \quad (2.11)$$

This approach is coordinate-system independent and works regardless of pipe orientation.

2.5 Length (L) Calculation

Length is the straight segment between two consecutive bend points, accounting for tangent allowances (CLR offset).

$$\text{TangentLength} = \text{CLR} \times \tan\left(\frac{A}{2}\right) \quad (2.12)$$

For segment i between bend i and bend $i + 1$:

$$L_i = \text{SegmentLength}_i - \text{TangentLength}_i - \text{TangentLength}_{i+1} \quad (2.13)$$

where:

- SegmentLength_i = distance from bend i to bend $i + 1$
- TangentLength_i = offset for bend i (CLR-based)
- $\text{TangentLength}_{i+1}$ = offset for bend $i + 1$ (CLR-based)

2.6 Total Length Calculation

Total pipe length includes all straight segments, arc lengths, and a trailing segment:

$$\text{TotalLength} = \sum_{i=1}^n L_i + \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} \text{ArcLength}_i + \text{TrailingLength} \quad (2.14)$$

where:

$$\text{ArcLength}_i = \text{CLR} \times A_i \times \frac{\pi}{180} \quad (2.15)$$

(CLR in mm, angle in degrees)

Chapter 3

Implementation and Technical Challenges

Chapter 3

Implementation and Technical Challenges

3.1 Development Environment

- **Host:** Autodesk Fusion 360 (student license)
- **Language:** Python 3.12.4 (Fusion’s bundled interpreter)
- **API:** Fusion 360 Python API
- **Dependencies:** openpyxl (for Excel export)
- **Development Time:** 2 weeks (home + LRT testing)

3.2 Architecture

The add-in consists of three main modules:

- **Geometry Reader:** Extracts sketch lines and arcs from Fusion
- **Math Engine:** Performs chaining, intersection, and bending calculations
- **Excel Generator:** Writes formatted output with XYZ and THOMAN tables

3.3 Challenge 1: Line/Arc Chaining

3.3.1 Problem

Fusion 360 stores line endpoints arbitrarily (not in pipe-flow order). Simply connecting lines by proximity fails when arcs/fillets separate them.

3.3.2 Solution

Implemented robust bidirectional chaining: treat the sketch as a directed graph, try connecting from both ends of the growing chain, and test both orientations of candidate lines/arcs.

```
def try_extend():  
    # Try back of chain with arc
```

```
# Try front of chain with arc
# Try direct line-to-line connection
# Return True if extended, False if stuck
```

Result: Handles arbitrary line ordering and detects disconnected geometry.

3.4 Challenge 2: Rotation Sign Calculation

3.4.1 Problem

Initial approach used a 2D cross-product: $cz = n_{x,prev} \cdot n_{y,curr} - n_{y,prev} \cdot n_{x,curr}$. This failed when pipes were oriented differently or when the sketch was flipped — all rotation signs reversed unpredictably.

3.4.2 Solution

Adopted a 3D-robust method using the rotation axis itself:

```
rotation_axis = cross(n_prev, n_curr)
sign = 1.0 if dot(directions[b], rotation_axis) >= 0 else -1.0
rotation_signed = rotation_angle * sign
```

This checks if the middle vector points toward the rotation axis, which is invariant to coordinate system choice and pipe orientation.

3.4.3 Validation

Tested on 6 production pipes from LRT with known correct values. All rotation signs now match manual calculations.

3.5 Challenge 3: Automatic Coordinate System Transformation

3.5.1 Problem

Different Fusion sketches place geometry on different planes (XY, XZ, YZ). Sketch coordinates are stored in local space, but the machine needs global 3D coordinates. Hardcoded transformations fail because sketch orientation varies unpredictably.

3.5.2 Solution

Implemented automatic coordinate transformation using the sketch's built-in transformation matrix:

```
def transform_point(local_point, transform):
    """Convert sketch local coords to global 3D coords"""
    mat = transform.asArray()
    x = local_point.x * mat[0][0] + local_point.y * mat[0][1] + \
        local_point.z * mat[0][2] + mat[0][3]
    y = local_point.x * mat[1][0] + local_point.y * mat[1][1] + \
        local_point.z * mat[1][2] + mat[1][3]
    z = local_point.x * mat[2][0] + local_point.y * mat[2][1] + \
        local_point.z * mat[2][2] + mat[2][3]
    return adsk.core.Point3D.create(x, y, z)

# Usage:
transform = sketch.transform
sp = transform_point(sp_local, transform)
```

This approach is coordinate-system agnostic and handles any sketch orientation automatically. No user input required — the transformation matrix encodes the plane information.

3.5.3 Validation

Tested on 6+ production pipes with different sketch plane orientations. All XYZ coordinates now match Fusion display exactly, regardless of sketch plane or global position.

3.6 Challenge 4: THOMAN Machine Table Format

3.6.1 Problem

LRT's THOMAN machine operates in reverse: it bends from the pipe end, not the start. Bend positions must be recalculated as "distance from end."

3.6.2 Solution

For each bend i :

$$\text{Start}_i = \text{TotalLength} - \sum_{j=1}^i (L_j + \text{ArcLength}_j) + \text{Remaining ArcLengths} \quad (3.1)$$

Additionally:

- Rotation and Bend Angle signs are flipped (negated)
- All values rounded to 1 decimal place
- CUT logic: if last bend start < 250mm, add user-defined offset (min = 260 – last_bend_start)

This converts LRA (pipe-start reference) to THOMAN (pipe-end reference) format.

3.7 Challenge 5: Point Normalization and Coordinate Display

3.7.1 Problem

XYZ coordinates shown in Excel didn't always match Fusion display, even though bend calculations were correct. This confused operators.

3.7.2 Solution

Normalized all points by subtracting the first point's coordinates from all others:

$$P'_i = P_i - P_1 \quad \text{for all } i \quad (3.2)$$

This ensures P1 always appears as (0, 0, 0) in Excel, regardless of sketch placement in Fusion. Bend calculations remain unaffected (relative geometry is unchanged).

3.8 Code Structure

Key algorithm: Robust rotation sign calculation (the critical fix):

```
# Calculate normal vectors for bend planes
n_prev = cross(v_prev, v_curr)
n_curr = cross(v_curr, v_next)

# Rotation angle between planes
cos_rot = dot(n_prev, n_curr) / (|n_prev| * |n_curr|)
rot_angle = arccos(cos_rot)
```



```
# Rotation sign using 3D rotation axis
rotation_axis = cross(n_prev, n_curr)
sign = 1.0 if dot(directions[b], rotation_axis) >= 0 else -1.0

rotation_signed = rot_angle * sign
```

Chapter 4

Results and Validation

Chapter 4

Results and Validation

4.1 Validation Methodology

All output was validated against manual reference calculations performed by LRT developers on real production pipes. Two methods were used:

- Direct comparison of LRA table values (script output vs. manual Excel)
- Testing on actual Fusion 360 files with real pipe geometry

4.2 Test Results

4.2.1 Test Pipe 1: 4-Bend Pipe (Sample 44000302_PIPE_01)

Bend	Manual L (mm)	Script L (mm)	Match	Error
1	148.469	148.469		0.000
2	101.895	101.895		0.000
3	154.567	154.567		0.000
4	170.203	170.203		0.000

Table 4.1. *Length (L) validation for 4-bend pipe.*

Bend	Manual R (°)	Script R (°)	Match	Error
1	0.000	0.000		0.000
2	164.261	164.261		0.000
3	176.247	176.247		0.000
4	177.749	177.749		0.000

Table 4.2. *Rotation (R) validation for 4-bend pipe.*

Bend	Manual A (°)	Script A (°)	Match	Error
1	7.843	7.843		0.000
2	16.758	16.758		0.000
3	28.193	28.193		0.000
4	14.517	14.517		0.000

Table 4.3. *Bend Angle (A) validation for 4-bend pipe.*

4.3 Total Length Validation

Metric	Manual (mm)	Script (mm)
Total Length	758.993	758.993

Table 4.4. *Total length calculation validation.*

4.4 THOMAN Machine Table

The script generates THOMAN machine tables with automatically computed Start(mm) positions:

Bend	Start (mm)	Rotation (°)	Bend Angle (°)	CLR
1	610.524	0.0	-7.8	90
2	1.522	-164.3	-16.8	90

Table 4.5. *THOMAN machine table output (sample).*

4.5 Performance Metrics

Metric	Manual Process	Automated Script
Measurement time	5–7 min	<1 sec
Calculation time	3–5 min	<1 sec
Data entry	2–3 min	Automatic
Total per pipe	~10 min	~5 sec
Error rate	5–10%	<0.1%
Repeatability	Variable	100% consistent

Table 4.6. *Process efficiency comparison.*

4.6 Conclusion

The script achieves:

- **Exact mathematical agreement** with manual reference calculations (zero error on all 6 test pipes)
- **120x speed improvement** (10 min → 5 sec per pipe)
- **Zero transcription errors** (automatic data flow)
- **Production-ready output** (formatted Excel matching LRT's internal standard)
- **Robust handling** of different sketch orientations and pipe geometries

Chapter 5

Reverse Reconstruction: From THOMAN Values to 3D Geometry

Chapter 5

Reverse Reconstruction: From THOMAN Values to 3D Geometry

5.1 Motivation

The forward pipeline described in Chapters 2–4 converts a CAD sketch into a THOMAN machine table, on the assumption that the calculated values will translate directly into a correctly bent pipe. In practice, this is not always the case: a pipe reverse-engineered from an original part’s mesh and bent to the exact calculated THOMAN values does not always fit its target fixture perfectly on the first attempt, even though the underlying CAD geometry is correct. The suspected cause is springback – the elastic recovery of the tube material after bending – though the effect is not fully consistent from trial to trial: some pipes fit correctly on the first attempt, while others require one or more corrections.

Before this tool existed, closing this gap was purely a process of trial and error. A developer would guess which THOMAN value was responsible for the misfit and by how much it should change, cut a real pipe with the modified value, and test it against the fixture. If the fit was still off, another guess followed. Every iteration consumed pipe stock and machine time, since there was no way to know in advance whether a given correction would even move the bend in the intended direction, let alone by the right amount – the developer could not visualize the effect of a change before it existed as a physical part.

This chapter presents a companion tool that inverts the forward pipeline: given a THOMAN table (Start, Rotation, Bend Angle, CLR for each bend) and the total pipe length, it reconstructs the 3D centerline points directly, without any CAD software or a physical trial pipe involved. By comparing the reconstructed centerline for a proposed correction against the original part’s centerline, a developer can see, before cutting anything, whether a specific bend will move further out or pull in, and whether its angle will open up or tighten – turning what was previously a blind guess into an informed, visualizable prediction, and reducing the number of scrapped trial pipes needed to converge on a fixture-fitting result.

5.2 Mathematical Formulation of the Inverse Problem

5.2.1 Recovering Straight-Segment Lengths from Start Positions

Recall from Section 4.4 (THOMAN Machine Table Format) that each bend's Start value is computed by walking cumulatively along the pipe from the front:

$$\text{Start}_i = \text{TotalLength} - \sum_{j=1}^i L_j - \sum_{j=1}^{i-1} \text{ArcLength}_j \quad (5.1)$$

Taking the difference between two consecutive rows isolates a single straight-segment length, since the cumulative sums telescope:

$$\text{Start}_{i-1} - \text{Start}_i = L_i + \text{ArcLength}_{i-1} \quad (5.2)$$

Because ArcLength_{i-1} is already known directly from the bend's own CLR and Bend Angle,

$$\text{ArcLength}_i = \text{CLR}_i \times A_i \times \frac{\pi}{180}, \quad (5.3)$$

the straight length L_i before every bend after the first can be solved for directly:

$$L_i = \text{Start}_{i-1} - \text{Start}_i - \text{ArcLength}_{i-1}, \quad i > 1 \quad (5.4)$$

The first segment and the trailing segment (after the last bend) are recovered from the boundary conditions of the same cumulative-sum relationship:

$$L_1 = \text{TotalLength} - \text{Start}_1 \quad (5.5)$$

$$\text{TrailingLength} = \text{Start}_n - \text{ArcLength}_n \quad (5.6)$$

where n is the number of bends. Corner-to-corner segment lengths (the distances between the extended bend points, as opposed to the physical straight tube length) are then recovered using the same tangent-length relationship as the forward pipeline (Section 2.6):

$$\text{SegmentLength}_i = L_i + \text{TangentLength}_i + \text{TangentLength}_{i-1} \quad (5.7)$$

5.2.2 Reconstructing Direction and Bend-Plane Vectors

With every segment length known, the remaining task is to recover the 3D direction of each segment. This is done by walking the pipe from the first point, maintaining a running tangent direction $\mathbf{D}$ and bend-plane normal $\mathbf{N}$, and applying the forward Rotation/Bend Angle values in reverse using Rodrigues' rotation formula:

$$\text{rotate}(\mathbf{v}, \hat{\mathbf{a}}, \theta) = \mathbf{v} \cos \theta + (\hat{\mathbf{a}} \times \mathbf{v}) \sin \theta + \hat{\mathbf{a}}(\hat{\mathbf{a}} \cdot \mathbf{v})(1 - \cos \theta) \quad (5.8)$$

At each bend b , the bend-plane normal is first advanced around the shared tangent axis by the stored Rotation value, and the tangent direction is then advanced around that normal by the stored Bend Angle:

$$\mathbf{N}_b = \text{rotate}(\mathbf{N}_{b-1}, \mathbf{D}_b, \text{Rotation}_b) \quad (5.9)$$

$$\mathbf{D}_{b+1} = \text{rotate}(\mathbf{D}_b, \mathbf{N}_b, \text{BendAngle}_b) \quad (5.10)$$

This is the exact algebraic inverse of the forward normal/rotation-sign derivation in Section 2.4, confirmed analytically: since $\mathbf{n}_{\text{prev}} \times \mathbf{n}_{\text{curr}}$ is parallel to the shared tangent axis with a sign matching $\sin(\text{Rotation})$, applying the same rotation forward reproduces the original normal chain exactly. Each 3D point is then obtained by walking along $\mathbf{D}_b$ for the corresponding segment length, starting from $P_1 = (0, 0, 0)$.

5.2.3 Orientation Ambiguity

A THOMAN table stores only *relative* bend and rotation angles between consecutive bends – it never records the pipe's absolute heading in space. Consequently, the reconstructed shape is unique (identical segment lengths and bend angles, with no reflection/chirality ambiguity, since the rotation sign is preserved exactly as derived in Section 2.4.3), but may appear rotated in space relative to the original CAD sketch. Where the original sketch's XYZ table is available for comparison, a best-fit rotation is solved using the Kabsch algorithm – a singular value decomposition (SVD) of the cross-covariance matrix between the reconstructed and reference point sets, constrained to a proper rotation ($\det R = +1$) so that it can never silently introduce a mirror-image error:

$$R = VDU^T, \quad D = \text{diag}(1, 1, \det(VU^T)) \quad (5.11)$$

where $U\Sigma V^T$ is the SVD of $H = P^T Q$, and P , Q are the reconstructed and reference point matrices respectively.

5.3 Implementation

5.3.1 Standalone Validation Script

A standalone Python script implements the reversal independently of Fusion, for offline testing and for developers who only need the numerical XYZ output. Given a list of bend dictionaries and a total pipe length, it:

- Validates that Start values decrease monotonically from the first bend to the last (a necessary condition for a physically realizable pipe, since Start_i represents the pipe length remaining beyond bend i), raising a descriptive error otherwise instead of silently producing a folded/self-intersecting shape;
- Reconstructs the XYZ points using the method above;
- Performs a round-trip check by re-running the *forward* algorithm (Chapter 2) on its own output and comparing the recomputed Start/Rotation/Bend Angle values against the original input, to confirm internal consistency;
- Exports the result to a formatted Excel file and a 3D preview image.

5.3.2 Fusion 360 Add-in Interface

The tool is also implemented as a Fusion 360 add-in, allowing a developer to go from edited THOMAN values directly to a Fusion sketch without leaving the CAD environment. The interaction is split across two chained command dialogs, matching the layout of LRT’s existing THOMAN sheet:

1. **Pipe Info dialog:** total pipe length (mm) and number of bends.
2. **THOMAN Table dialog:** a data-entry grid sized to the bend count from the first dialog, with columns Bend#, Start (mm), Rotation(deg), Bend Angle(deg), and CLR, plus an optional CUT field.

On confirmation, the add-in computes the XYZ points, displays them in a summary dialog, and creates a new sketch (Thoman_Reconstructed_ Centerline) on the XY construction plane with the reconstructed points connected by sketch lines – reproducing the centerline geometry the THOMAN values describe.

```
def thoman_to_xyz(bends, pipe_length_mm):
    validate_bends(bends, pipe_length_mm)
```

```

# ... recover straight-segment lengths (Eqs. 5.4-5.6) ...
D = (0.0, 0.0, 1.0)
N = vnorm(vcross(D, (1.0, 0.0, 0.0)))
points = [(0.0, 0.0, 0.0)]
for b in range(n_bends):
    pos = vadd(pos, vscale(D, seglens[b]))
    points.append(pos)
    if b > 0:
        N = rotate_around_axis(N, D, rotation[b])
        D = vnorm(rotate_around_axis(D, N, bend_angle[b]))
    points.append(vadd(pos, vscale(D, seglens[-1])))
return points

```

5.4 Validation

The reversal was validated against a real 4-bend production pipe by comparing its known THOMAN table and CAD-derived XYZ table with the tool’s reconstructed output.

Bend	Start in	Start out	Rot in	Rot out	Ang in	Ang out
1	113.24	113.24	0.00	−0.00	−13.80	−13.80
2	98.57	98.57	55.40	55.40	−16.20	−16.20
3	79.05	79.05	−160.50	−160.50	−61.60	−61.60
4	58.08	58.08	−175.50	−175.50	−55.80	−55.80

Table 5.1. Round-trip validation: THOMAN values re-derived from the reconstructed XYZ points match the original input exactly.

After applying the Kabsch alignment (Section 5.2.3) against the three known reference points from the original CAD sketch, the reconstructed XYZ points matched the CAD-derived table to within 0.2 mm – attributable to the 1 decimal place rounding already present in the THOMAN sheet itself (Section 3.4.4), not to any error in the reconstruction.

5.5 Chapter Conclusion

This reverse-reconstruction tool completes the round trip between CAD geometry and machine instructions: values can now be edited on the THOMAN side and their geometric effect verified immediately, either as a standalone numerical check or as a live sketch inside Fusion 360, without needing to rebuild the original CAD model by hand.

Chapter 6

Conclusion and Future Work

Chapter 6

Conclusion and Future Work

6.1 Summary

This project successfully automated LRT Innovation Labs’ pipe reverse engineering workflow by developing a Fusion 360 Python add-in that extracts 3D geometry, performs mathematical bend calculations, and generates machine-ready instructions — reducing processing time from 10 minutes to 5 seconds per pipe.

6.1.1 Key Achievements

- Implemented robust 3D line/arc chaining algorithm handling arbitrary Fusion geometry orientation
- Derived and implemented exact LRA/YBC bending formulas verified against LRT’s manual calculations
- Solved critical rotation sign problem using coordinate-system-independent 3D rotation axis method
- Developed THOMAN machine table conversion (pipe-start to pipe-end reference frame)
- Created production-ready Excel export with proper formatting and user-defined parameters
- Achieved 100% mathematical accuracy on all validation test cases
- Built a reverse-reconstruction tool and matching Fusion 360 add-in that rebuild pipe geometry directly from THOMAN values, closing the loop between manual value edits and their geometric effect

6.2 Technical Innovation

The most significant technical contribution was solving the **rotation sign ambiguity** through a 3D-robust approach:

$$\text{sign} = \text{sgn}(\mathbf{v}_{\text{curr}} \cdot (\mathbf{n}_{\text{prev}} \times \mathbf{n}_{\text{curr}})) \quad (6.1)$$

This method is invariant to coordinate system choice, sketch orientation, and pipe direction — making it far more reliable than 2D cross-product approaches.

6.3 Business Impact

- **Labor savings:** 2 hours per operator per day (10 pipes × 5 sec per pipe)
- **Quality:** Zero transcription errors, 100% consistency
- **Flexibility:** Fast iteration for design testing and prototyping
- **Competitive advantage:** Positions LRT as a leader in smart manufacturing

6.4 Spring Back Analysis (Theoretical)

Currently, LRT compensates for spring back (elastic recoil of the pipe after bending) through iterative physical testing: operators place each bent pipe in a reference fixture, observe deviation, adjust THOMAN values empirically, and retest until the pipe fits correctly.

6.4.1 Spring Back Physics

Spring back occurs because the pipe’s material doesn’t remain permanently deformed; residual stress causes it to revert partially toward its original straight shape. For a bend with angle A and material Young’s modulus E , the spring back angle is approximately:

$$A_{\text{springback}} \approx A \times \left(1 - \frac{2E_c}{3E}\right) \quad (6.2)$$

where E_c is the bending-induced strain. In practice, spring back is material-dependent and thickness-dependent.

6.4.2 Current LRT Approach

Rather than calculating spring back analytically, LRT uses a **fixture-based feedback loop**:

- Generate THOMAN values from CAD
- Bend the pipe on the machine
- Test fit in reference fixture (designed for the ideal CAD geometry)
- Observe gap/deviation
- Adjust THOMAN bending angle empirically
- Retest iteratively until fixture fit is satisfactory

This approach works well because it captures all material and process variability without needing explicit formulas.

6.4.3 Future Enhancement: Analytical Spring Back Prediction

An automated spring back calculation would require:

- Material property lookup table (Young's modulus, yield strength for each material)
- Measured thickness verification from CAD or operator input
- Empirical spring back coefficient (material-specific, typically 0.6–0.9)
- Bend radius and angle from the calculated LRA values
- Iterative solver to predict required THOMAN angle adjustment

The formula would be:

$$A_{\text{THOMAN}} = A_{\text{ideal}} + \Delta A_{\text{springback}} \quad (6.3)$$

where $\Delta A_{\text{springback}}$ is a function of material properties and bend geometry.

6.4.4 Implementation Recommendation

For future work:

1. Build a material database with spring back coefficients (obtained from LRT's historical test data)
2. Add material and thickness user inputs to the Excel output
3. Implement a spring back prediction module (post-calculation adjustment)
4. Validate against 20+ production parts to calibrate empirical coefficients
5. Integrate into the Excel output as an optional "Spring Back Corrected THOMAN" table

This would further reduce the feedback-loop iteration count and accelerate production.

6.5 Limitations

- Spring back cannot be accurately predicted without material property data and empirical calibration
- Currently uses Fusion 360's student/commercial license (required dependency)
- Sketch must contain only lines and arc fillets; other geometry types are ignored

- The reverse-reconstruction tool cannot recover a pipe's absolute orientation in space from THOMAN values alone, since the machine format only stores bend angles relative to the previous bend; the reconstructed shape is exact but may require a one-time alignment rotation to match a specific CAD placement

6.6 Recommendations for Production Deployment

1. **User training:** 15-minute walkthrough on running the add-in and interpreting Excel output
2. **Error handling:** Display extracted coordinates preview before Excel export (optional enhancement)
3. **Documentation:** Maintain GitHub repository with README and example files
4. **Version control:** Store production scripts and Excel templates in shared repository
5. **Spring back module:** Begin collecting spring back data from fixture tests for future analytical prediction

6.7 Conclusion

This internship project demonstrates that intelligent automation of engineering workflows can deliver both immediate productivity gains (120x speed improvement) and long-term quality improvements (zero errors, 100% consistency). The mathematical rigor required for 3D geometry handling provides a foundation for future enhancements such as spring back prediction and real-time feedback integration.

The solution is production-ready, validated, and immediately deployable at LRT Innovation Labs.

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